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The discourse community I am focusing on is the Killington Ski School and its closely connected Mountain Operations team. Members of this community typically refer to themselves as “instructors,” “patrol,” “mountain ops,” or by certification level (such as PSIA Level 1,2 or 3). This community exists to provide safe, effective ski instruction while coordinating with patrol, lift operations, snowmaking, and grooming to manage risk and maintain efficient resort operations. It includes full-time and part-time instructors, trainers, supervisors, ski patrol, and operations managers. The community values safety, technical precision, communication clarity, and professionalism, especially because mistakes can lead to serious injury. I came to know this community through working as an instructor, attending clinics and briefings, using radios, shadowing senior staff, and participating in daily operational meetings and training sessions.

Beyond technical communication, this discourse community is defined by a strong apprenticeship model in which knowledge is passed down through observation, practice, and evaluation. New instructors are not immediately fluent in the community’s slang and jargon; instead they learn how to speak and act “ like an instructor” through shadowing lessons, attending clinics, and receiving formal feedback during on hill evaluations. This process reflects

Swales' idea that discourse communities control membership by regulating access to a valued language and skillset.

There is also a clear distinction between how members communicate with guests versus how they communicate with one another. Instructors often translate biomechanical and technical terms into metaphors and simplified language for beginners, while using precise PSIA terminology when speaking with trainers or writing reports. This code-switching demonstrates how members negotiate meaning depending on audience and purpose, aligning with Tremain's discussion of code-meshing and language adaptation with professional communities.